

01

What a Headline Actually Does

Document 1 of 8

New to this series? Start here — this document defines the vocabulary every other document uses.

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The 80% Rule: Why the Headline Is the Whole Game

Here is the most important statistic in copywriting: roughly 8 out of 10 people who see your ad will read the headline — and only 2 out of 10 will read anything else. One classic teaching puts it even more bluntly: about 80% of people only ever read the headline. It isn't a garnish on your copy; it's the cherry on the ice cream sundae that most people never dig past.

Think about what that means for where your effort should go. You can write the most persuasive body copy in the world, but if the headline fails, that copy is invisible. Five times as many people read your headline as read your body copy. Every dollar you spend on traffic is really a bet on a single line of text.

This is why the old direct-response masters called the headline **"the ad for the ad."** Its job is not to sell the product. Its job is to sell the act of reading the next line. If it does that, the rest of the copy gets its chance. If it doesn't, nothing else you wrote exists.

The Attention Filter

Why do readers behave this way? Because headlines are how modern readers survive information overload. A person scrolling a feed sees hundreds of competing messages an hour. They cannot read them all, so they use headlines as time-saving filters — visual speed-bumps that let them decide, in about a second, "is this for me or not?"

That second is your entire window. The reader is not looking for reasons to read your ad; they are looking for reasons to skip it. A headline earns attention by doing one thing instantly: signaling *this is about you, and it matters to you*. Everything else in this series — benefits, curiosity, angles, believability, word choice — is in service of winning that one-second decision, over and over, at each step of your funnel.

The One Universal Law: A Headline Sells Only the Next Commitment

A headline never sells the product. It sells exactly one thing: the very next step.

- The **ad** headline sells the **click**.
- The **advertorial** headline sells the **read**.
- The **jump page** (also called a bridge page) headline sells the **play** — pressing play on the video that follows.

The sales page or video does the actual selling. Nobody in the chain should try to do anybody else's job. When a headline reaches past its own step — an ad headline that tries to close a sale, a jump-page headline that tries to deliver the whole argument — it leaks the tension the next step needed, and response drops.

This is also why "is this a good headline?" is an incomplete question. A headline can only be judged against the commitment it is supposed to win. A brilliant advertorial headline is usually a terrible ad headline, and vice versa. Whenever you write or evaluate a headline, your first move is always the same: name the surface it lives on.

The Three Surfaces

1. The ad headline — sells the CLICK. The reader is at their coldest: scrolling a content feed in discovery mode, not searching for anything. The ad headline's job is to stop the scroll, signal "this is for me," and win a *qualified* click. It is the most curiosity-weighted surface — you open a loop and deliberately do not close it. The register is editorial: it must read like content the reader already trusts, never like a coupon or a hard sell. It also carries the tightest platform-policy exposure — ad networks review these headlines directly, so honest framing and claim discipline are survival requirements, not fine print. Success metric: click-through rate, but a qualified one. A curiosity trick that wins cheap, wrong clicks poisons everything downstream.

2. The advertorial headline — sells the READ. The reader has clicked and landed on a long-form, editorial-style page. They are warmer, but skeptical: they're deciding whether this article deserves the next three minutes of their life. The advertorial headline restates and enlarges the promise that earned the click, adds enough substance (a story, a specific result, a named discovery) to feel like journalism, and pulls the reader into the first paragraph. It can be longer and more layered than an ad headline — research on native content found engagement peaked at roughly sentence-length, story-telling headlines here. Success metric: read-through — how far down the page people go.

3. The jump-page headline — sells the PLAY. The reader has read (or skimmed) the middle page and arrived at a short page whose only purpose is to hand them to a video. They are at their hottest. The jump-page headline restates the core promise at full intensity, names what the video will show, and points all momentum at the play button. It is the most direct, least coy surface. Success metric: play rate.

Same product, same angle — three different jobs, three different headlines.

The Headline Unit

Throughout this series, "headline" means the **headline unit** — the headline alone, or the headline plus subheadline working together as one persuasion unit. The psychological elements of the message are distributed across the pair; there are no fixed rules about which element must sit in the headline versus the subheadline. The split is decided by above-the-fold hierarchy and scannability: the headline carries the sharpest, most magnetic part of the idea, and the subheadline carries supporting weight — proof, constraints, mechanism detail — that would make the headline bulky. If everything fits cleanly in one line, you may not need a subheadline at all.

The subheadline also creates what old-school copywriters called a **double readership path**: skimmers who will never read your paragraphs still absorb the promise, because the headline unit tells enough of the story on its own.

Three Classic Swipes, Annotated

SWIPE

"What Everybody Ought to Know About This Stock and Bond Business" (a famous classic ad)

ANATOMY [Universal Curiosity Frame] + [Specific Topic the Reader Feels Under-Informed About].

WHY IT WORKS "What everybody ought to know" implies a knowledge gap the reader is embarrassed to have. It sells the read without making a single claim — pure attention-filter bait for a topic people quietly worry about.

FUNNEL FIT Advertorial — it promises an *education*, which is exactly what an editorial page can deliver.

SWIPE

"The Tool Over 283,000 Websites Use to Grow Their Traffic"

ANATOMY [Unnamed Tool] + [Oddly Specific Social Proof Number] + [Universal Benefit].

WHY IT WORKS The tool is withheld (curiosity), the number is too specific to be invented (believability), and the benefit is one the reader already wants. Three jobs in eleven words.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — it sells the click by making the reader need to know *which* tool.

SWIPE

"If You Read Nothing Else – READ THIS!"

ANATOMY [Acknowledgment of Skimming Behavior] + [Direct Command].

WHY IT WORKS It meets the reader exactly where they are — mid-skim — and converts their own behavior into a reason to stop. Urgency without a single claim.

FUNNEL FIT Jump page — a hot reader needs momentum and direction, not a new argument.

Fictional Before/After: From Product-Name to Headline Unit

Imagine you're promoting a fictional ergonomic seat cushion called the LumbarCloud.

Before (product-first, no unit):

LumbarCloud — The Advanced Ergonomic Seat Cushion

This is a label, not a headline. It sells the product's *name*, which the reader doesn't care about, and it gives the attention filter nothing to catch.

After (a curiosity-driven headline unit):

Headline: Why Desk Workers Are Ditching Expensive Office Chairs for This Odd-Looking Cushion **Subheadline:** A physical therapist's simple "3-point support" design is easing years of desk-chair back ache — often in the first week.

The headline sells the click with an open loop (why? which cushion?). The subheadline carries the supporting weight: who's behind it, the named mechanism, the believable timeframe. Together they tell enough of the story that even a skimmer walks away with the promise — and a curious reader has to click.

✓ Key Takeaways

- Roughly 80% of your audience reads *only* the headline. It deserves a matching share of your effort.
- The headline is "the ad for the ad": it never sells the product, only the very next commitment.
- There are three surfaces, each with one job: the ad sells the **click**, the advertorial sells the **read**, the jump page sells the **play**.
- Never judge a headline in a vacuum — first name the surface it lives on, then judge it against that surface's job.
- "Headline" always means the **headline unit**: headline alone, or headline plus subheadline working as one persuasion unit, with the split decided by above-the-fold hierarchy and scannability.
- A subheadline creates a double readership path so even skimmers absorb the promise.